

1. THE CHARACTER OF A HAPPY LIFE

BY SIR HENRY WOTTON

March 30, 1568 – December 1639

"Character of a Happy Life" by Sir Henry Wotton is a thoughtful poem that describes the qualities of a truly happy person. The poet suggests that real happiness comes not from wealth or fame, but from honesty, simplicity, inner peace, and freedom from worldly pressures. It emphasizes that a virtuous life, lived with integrity, is the key to lasting joy.



How happy is he born and taught
That serveth not another's will;
Whose armour is his honest thought,
And simple truth his utmost skill!

Whose passions not his masters are;
Whose soul is still prepared for death,
Untied unto the world by care
Of public fame or private breath;

Who envies none that chance doth raise,
Nor vice; who never understood
How deepest wounds are given by praise;
Nor rules of state, but rules of good;

Who hath his life from rumours freed;
Whose conscience is his strong retreat;
Whose state can neither flatterers feed,
Nor ruin make oppressors great;

Who God doth late and early pray
More of His grace than gifts to lend;
And entertains the harmless day
With a religious book or friend;

—This man is freed from servile bands
Of hope to rise or fear to fall:
Lord of himself, though not of lands,
And having nothing, yet hath all.

EXERCISE 1- WORDS/EXPRESSIONS & THEIR MEANINGS

S. #	Words	Meaning in English
1.	Severth	Serves
2.	Utmost	Highest Greatness
3.	Private Breath	What people say about him in private
4.	Vice	Immoral Habits
5.	Conscience	Awareness of right and wrong
6.	Retreat	Place of Safety
7.	Flattetrers	People who praises you falsely
8.	Oppressors	Tyrants
9.	Servile Bands	Slavish Bonds

EXERCISE 1- POST READING

Q1) What is the wealth of the person having a good life?

Ans. The most striking and attractive quality of the character of happy life is that he conquers and controls his emotions and feelings easily and has not any desire for worldly possession and that is the quality which makes him the owner of himself rather than the owner of the land. It is true that the character of a happy life has not any material wealth but he gets immeasurable eternal and spiritual wealth because of his pious and simple nature.

Q2. How is a happy man master of his passions? OR 'Whose passions not his masters are'. Explain the following line?

Ans. The poet says that a happy man's passions are way under his control. His passions and desires are at the back of his mind and he remembers his death. He knows death can come anytime. So he is prepared for death and to depart to the world hereafter. A happy man does not care about the worries and problems of the material world. He has no lust for power or wealth and stays away from distractions of the worldly life. He does what he thinks is right and acts according to the dictates of his conscience.

Q3. Why does Sir Henry Wotton's happy man pray God and how does he pass his days?

Ans. Sir Henry Wotton's happy man completely dedicates his life to pray god and loves to pray to Him every time. He not only says thanks to God for every blessing and kindness that have been bestowed upon him but also seeks His mercy. He prefers to pass his time with the company of wisely selected people and enjoys a peaceful religiously company with a spiritual pious person and religious books.

Q4. What are the armor and the greatest skill of the person who leads a happy life?

Ans. The person who leads a happy life always prefers to select his honest thinking as his armor and defends himself by his honest thinking from every type of sin that can destroy and spoil his character. The greatest skill that the character of happy life adopts is the simple truth that always saves him from any forged and artificial statement and that is the art of his living.

"Honesty is the first chapter of the book of wisdom".

Thomas Jefferson

"If you tell the truth. You don't have to remember anything"

Mark Twain

Q5) How does the praise give the deepest wounds?

Ans. False praise can be the source to destroy the character of humanity and for the character of happy life is to stay away from all sort of false praises because they all are given by some cause or personal benefits and they all misguided and bluffed.

Q6) What is the importance of conscience in a happy man's life?

Ans. Conscience plays an important role in the character building of everyone either he is an upright or not because it plays a major part in the selection of vice and virtue. If going on the good path your conscience is satisfied so you must not fear the consequences and do freely. The character of a happy life has no other shelter but his strong conscience.

"Good friends, good books and a sleepy conscience this is the ideal life".

Mark Twain

Q7. What are the qualities of a happy man as described in the poem "the Character of Happy life"?

Ans. Sir Henry Wotton describes in his poem "The character of Happy life" the qualities of a person who doesn't bind himself with this mortal world. This man has not any servile band; he just leads his life rightly. He never thinks about the materialistic thing and never envy anyone. He doesn't need any armor for his defense. He has only things that his honest thought and power to speak the truth in any condition of life. He doesn't pay ahead to what people think about him, he just follows his conscience. He always prays to God for His blessing and thanks to God, he doesn't keep any false hopes and hence doesn't have any feat to fall. He rules on his and apparently, he had nothing but he has everything.

Q8. Explain briefly how Sir Henry Wotton's happy man 'having nothing yet hath all'.

Ans. Sir Henry Wotton presented an idea of a happy man in his poem "The Character of Happy Life" that a happy man does not need any sort of armor for his defense because he does not give the importance of material source which needs defense. He has no public fame, desire to go upward and secret vaults to save something for a rainy day. He has only a heart which is totally free from any guilt and envy. So Henry Wotton says that He has nothing but he has everything.

Q9. Enlist few qualities of the man leading a happy life.

Ans. Sir Henry Wotton's happy man has so many righteous qualities. Some of them are listed below:

1. He is the man of his own will and wishes.
2. He selects the honesty as his armor defends himself and makes the truth his art of living.
3. He conquers and controls his emotions and feelings and ever ready to meet the moment of mortality
4. He consciously keeps away from the damages of fame and prefers the rules of goodness over the rules of State
5. Has no other shelter but his strong conscience.
6. He regularly prays to God seeks His mercy
7. He does not desire any worldly possessions
8. He enjoys a peaceful and religiously contended company with a pious person and religious books.
9. He has got immeasurable eternal and spiritual wealth.

Q10. What is the main idea of the poem 'Character of a happy life'?

Ans. The poem Character of a Happy Life gives an idea that a happy life is obtained by establishing a character with good qualities of a peaceful life. A person who always speaks the truth and remain steadfast on the path of Almighty, facing all the challenges boldly but not giving up. Can lead a peaceful and happy life. A man who is ready to give up the lust of the materialistic luxuries and fame, one who understands the idea of the temporariness of the human world, one who stays firm on the path of righteousness, one who remains thankful to God in the face of all the hardships, one who remains humble, humane and passionate throughout his life, such is an example of character of a happy life. Their piety and spiritual peace of mind not just makes them a character of happy life in this world, but they obtain an everlasting spiritual bliss and success in the world hereafter.

Q11. What is meant by servile bands? How is a happy man freed from servile bands?

Ans. Servile bands means slavish bonds. A happy man is free from slavish bonds because he has no desire of acquiring a high social position of chance or thorough wickedness nor he is afraid of losing the present position. He possesses exemplary good qualities like truth, patience, honesty and goodness which keep him away from slavish bonds.

Q12. How is a happy man lord of himself though he possesses no wealth, land and property?

Ans. A happy man is not the owner of wealth, land and property. Such things are usually taken as symbol of being rich, from worldly point of view. But a happy man is the lord of himself because he is the master of his own will. He appears to be poor from worldly point of view but according to moral and spiritual standards he is very rich. He possesses nobility of character and the spiritual wealth which makes his character par excellence, making his life most peaceful than the life of any luxurious man in the world.

EXERCISE 2- MULTIPLE CHOICE QUESTIONS

The strong retreat for a happy man is his

- A** drawing room
- B** tennis court
- C** mind
- D** conscience

According to Wotton's happy man always pray for

- A** blessings
- B** gold
- C** material things
- D** popularity

Wotton's happy man always remain

- A** overambitious
- B** lustful
- C** greedy
- D** self-controlled

In this poem, the poet describes the life of

- A** contentment
- B** disturbance
- C** hardships
- D** corruption

And having nothing, yet hath all Here "all" refers to?

- A** money
- B** property
- C** contentment
- D** control

A happy man is very much caring about

- A** worldly needs
- B** material uplift
- C** character
- D** finance

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The virtuous man's upmost skill is his

- A** truth
- B** art
- C** education
- D** armour

The upright man's armour is his

- A** pistol
- B** sword
- C** vicious thouht
- D** honest thought

Besides being a poet, Sir Henry Wotton was a/an

- A** duke
- B** earl
- C** bureaucrat
- D** technocrat

A happy man strictly observes the rules of

- A** statecraft
- B** goodness
- C** might is right
- D** traditions

The happy man passes his spare time in

- A** reading ethics and morality
- B** working to earn livelihood
- C** reading jokes
- D** reading fiction

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- A** reading ethics and morality
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The happy man strictly follows the

- A** articles of law
- B** articles of constitution
- C** heavenly commandments
- D** rules of judiciary

The major weapon of defence for a happy man is his

- A** virtuous act
- B** piety
- C** name and fame
- D** honest thought

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The ability of a virtuous man is his

- A** simple truth
- B** virtuous speech
- C** prayer
- D** nobility

The life of a happy man according to the poet is deeply

- A** Materialistic
- B** idealistic
- C** Religious
- D** Social